EIGHT CLASSICS, ONE FRIENDLY RULEBOOK

House Rule Cards

Print on cardstock, cut along the dashed lines, and keep them in the card box.

Picking house rules together is half the fun. These eight classics come with gentle, family-tested rules for keeping games quick, kind, and winnable by everyone. Mark which ones your table adopts, and write your own tweaks on the back before you laminate them.

Inside:

1. Go Fish - Collect the most sets of 4 matching ranks (four 7s, four kin...
2. Crazy Eights - Be first to empty your hand....
3. War - Win all the cards....
4. Old Maid - Make pairs - and don't get stuck with the lone Queen....
5. Memory Match - Find matching pairs. Sharpest memory wins....
6. Snap - Win the pile by spotting matching ranks first....
7. Slapjack - Win all cards by slapping the Jack... politely....
8. Quick Rummy - Be first to lay down a 3-card set (rummy) and go out....

Want the whole pack? It lives with your other favorites:

The Free Game Night Hosting Pack

01 House Rule Cards - this file

02 Score Sheets - four pads for every scoring style

03 Tournament Bracket - 8-player + 4-player mini

04 Snack-Plan Worksheet - balanced, low-effort snacks

05 All-Ages Tips - kids, grandparents, everyone

06 Wind-Down Checklist - the anti-meltdown plan

Go Fish

house rule card

GOAL Collect the most sets of 4 matching ranks (four 7s, four kings...).

SETUP Deal 5 cards each (7 cards if 2 players). Rest is the 'pond'.

OUR HOUSE RULES

* Ask anyone: 'Got any 5s?' - you must hold a 5 to ask for 5s.
* No match? 'Go fish!' Draw from the pond; your turn continues if you draw what you asked for.
* Completed sets go face-up for everyone to admire.

Tweak it: Easier: ask for matching colors, not ranks. Wilder: winner of each set takes another turn.

Circle the rules your table adopts

Crazy Eights

house rule card

GOAL Be first to empty your hand.

SETUP Deal 5 cards each. Flip one card up as the discard pile.

OUR HOUSE RULES

* Match the top card's suit or rank; eights are wild (pick the new suit).
* Stuck? Draw from the deck - our house rule: draw once, then play or pass.
* Play a 2 to make the next player draw 2 (stacks of fun, stacks optional by vote).

Tweak it: Easier: deal 3 cards and keep rules visible. Wilder: play a Queen to skip the next player.

Circle the rules your table adopts

War

house rule card

GOAL Win all the cards.

SETUP Deal the whole deck evenly, face down. No peeking!

OUR HOUSE RULES

* Everyone flips their top card at once; highest rank takes the pile. Aces high.
* Tie? 'War!' - flip one face-down, then one face-up; winner takes all.
* Play quick rounds: first to win 3 battles rests while others finish.

Tweak it: Shorter: play half the deck, count wins. Cooler: lowest card wins that round.

Circle the rules your table adopts

Old Maid

house rule card

GOAL Make pairs - and don't get stuck with the lone Queen.

SETUP Remove one Queen from the deck. Deal all cards out.

OUR HOUSE RULES

* Discard pairs as you get them, face-up.
* Hold your cards fanned out; each player draws one blind from the next hand.
* New pair? Lay it down happily. First to empty their hand wins the round.

Tweak it: Kindness rule: 'a fair warning' - before drawing you may ask 'any pairs left?' and peek at only one card.

Circle the rules your table adopts

Memory Match

house rule card

GOAL Find matching pairs. Sharpest memory wins.

SETUP Use half a deck (24-28 cards). Lay out in a grid, face down.

OUR HOUSE RULES

* Flip exactly 2 cards per turn, then flip them back if they don't match.
* A matched pair stays face-up and earns you another turn.
* No coaching from the peanut gallery - loving 'hmms' only.

Tweak it: Easier: fewer cards or a 10-second 'photo peek'. Harder: ban taking notes!

Circle the rules your table adopts

Snap

house rule card

GOAL Win the pile by spotting matching ranks first.

SETUP Deal all cards face down (no peeking).

OUR HOUSE RULES

* Players take turns flipping onto their own face-up pile.
* Top cards match on any pile? First to shout 'SNAP!' wins those piles.
* Agree a gentle volume: 'restaurant snap' voice, not stadium snap.

Tweak it: Slow mode: only your own two piles can snap. Kids mode: adults count to 3 before anyone snaps.

Circle the rules your table adopts

Slapjack

house rule card

GOAL Win all cards by slapping the Jack... politely.

SETUP Deal the whole deck face down.

OUR HOUSE RULES

* Flip cards onto one center pile in turn.
* A Jack appears? First hand on the pile wins it.
* House rule: flat-hand only, gentle slaps, no sliding tackles.

Tweak it: Add a second target card (like 7s) for extra suspense in a big group.

Circle the rules your table adopts

Quick Rummy

house rule card

GOAL Be first to lay down a 3-card set (rummy) and go out.

SETUP Deal 7 cards each. Flip one for the discard pile; one draw, one discard per turn.

OUR HOUSE RULES

* Draw from deck or top discard; end every turn by discarding one.
* Sets = same rank. Runs = 3 in a row, same suit.
* First to assemble one set lays it down and wins the round.

Tweak it: Two-set goal for longer nights; 'open hands' mode so a helper can coach a learner.

Circle the rules your table adopts